

MAPUTO MOZAMBIQUE

All Fired Up in Mozambique

Lapped by the balmy Indian Ocean, Maputo is probably the most characterful capital city in sub-equatorial Africa. A seaside port, its wide palm- and jacaranda-shaded *avenidas* are flanked by cozy street cafés and an oddly cohesive cocktail of architectural styles. The city possesses an engaging Afro-Mediterranean mood epitomized by the addictive, fiery zip of chicken piri-piri.



Five centuries ago, the desire to secure control of the spice trade inspired Portugal to establish outposts along the east coast of Africa, one of which grew to become the modern Mozambican capital of Maputo. Today, the most notoriously tongue-searing of these spices – the ferocious chili pepper known by the Swahili-derived name piri-piri – forms the cornerstone of Mozambique’s best-known culinary export.

Mozambique’s struggle for independence from Portugal ended as recently as 1974, and the legacy of colonial rule can still be seen in the fascinating architecture of its capital city. Antiquated colonial relics and handsome Art Deco and Bauhaus buildings stand out among bleak Soviet-style apartment blocks, relics of a period of Marxist-oriented government that

inspired a bitter civil war. And it is the juxtaposition of the city’s contemporary African culture against this time-warped architectural exotica that makes Maputo so compelling. For example, one of Africa’s most bizarrely misplaced buildings – a stately palace built in ornate Portuguese Gothic style that now houses the Natural History Museum – sits just around the corner from the utterly African Barracas de Museu. This unpretentious, vast warren of makeshift stands and bars is inhabited by a bustling cast of guitar-bearing rent-a-crooners, beer-swilling mamas, wild-eyed pool hustlers, and after-hours office workers. It is dedicated to the sale and consumption of alcohol and there is no better place to make new friends over a cold Mozambican beer and a sizzling plate of chicken piri-piri.

No other dish is quite so definitely Mozambican as this – spatchcocked chicken, grilled to perfection over hot coals in its mantle of piquant piri-piri sauce. Deep red and viscous, the sauce is dominated by the chili pepper for which it is named, which is finely chopped and soaked in vegetable oil, garlic, vinegar, lemon juice, and coarse salt – and whatever other secret ingredient it is that ensures that, whether you’re ordering at a street stall, a hole-in-the-wall carry-out or an upmarket restaurant, no two versions of this unofficial national dish ever taste exactly the same.

What Else to Eat

Maputo, almost uniquely among sub-equatorial African capitals, has long been renowned for its dining-out scene. In the colonial era the city was noted, as it still is now, for its fine **seafood**. Particularly famous are the country’s **shrimp** (often referred to in southern Africa as LM prawns, after Maputo’s old colonial name, Lourenço Marques), which are usually served grilled, with garlic or piri-piri sauce on the side, or baked in a beer-based sauce. The **Costa do Sol** (see right) is renowned for its shrimp and seafood combos (try the grilled fish and calamari), and there’s no finer exponent of sauce-baked shrimp than the **1908 Restaurant** (+258 21 304 428), set in a beautiful colonial house on Av. Eduardo Mondlane.

Left High-rise buildings give way to beachside homes on the outskirts



The Best Places to Eat Chicken Piri-Piri

Restaurante Costa do Sol

moderate–expensive

Boasting a prime seafront location 5 miles (8 km) north of downtown, the legendary Costa do Sol is the oldest eatery in Maputo, having operated continuously since the 1940s, and throughout the civil war that drove Mozambique to an economic standstill in the 1980s. Fittingly, this family-run institution has a somewhat time-warped Mediterranean ambience, with its Art Deco facade, wide terrace overlooking a palm-lined beach and gentle rolling breakers, reasonably priced daily specials chalked up on a board, white-starched tablecloths, and famously erratic (but invariably friendly) service. As with most restaurants in Maputo, seafood features heavily on the menu, but the Costa do Sol also arguably serves the city’s finest grilled chicken: marinated in a spicy sauce, sealed and flame-grilled on an open fire and accompanied by a bowl of fiery red sauce whose searing chili pepper base is, like all the best piri-piri, offset by a delicious tang from the addition of preserved lemons. A chilled Sauvignon Blanc from neighboring South Africa provides the perfect accompaniment, though the locally brewed 2M lager might be a safer bet for dousing the fiery aftertaste.

Av. de Marginal; open 11 AM–10:30 PM Sun–Thu, 11 AM–midnight Fri & Sat; +258 21 450 115

Also in Maputo

As might be surmised from the restaurant’s name, the chef at **Piri-piri** (+258 21 492 379; *moderate*), an ever-popular eatery in the heart of the upmarket Polana district, isn’t afraid of dousing his grilled chicken in antisocial quantities of delicious piri-piri sauce. Aside from the good food, the terrace here, where Av. 24 de Julho and Av. Julius Nyerere meet, has to be one of the city’s top spots for people-watching.

Also in Mozambique

Tucked away on an anonymous dirt road in Vilankulo, one of Mozambique’s top resort towns, is **Varanda** (+258 29 382 412; *moderate*), a family-run restaurant famed for its seafood and superb chicken piri-piri. It overlooks a beach where fishing dhows come to land their catches in the evening.

Around the World

Unsurprisingly, Mozambique’s most famous dish long ago made it across two oceans to its former colonizer, Portugal, where it has become a local specialty at the picturesque village of Guia, in the central Algarve. There are several restaurants to choose from here, but none finer than the veteran **Restaurant Ramires** (+351 289 561 232; *inexpensive*), which has been firing up visitors’ taste buds for over 25 years.

